Trans Naming Practices and the Social Meaning of Names

Abstract:

Transgender renaming has largely gone unexamined in philosophy of language. I offer an account of it as a replacement speech practice – an attempt to displace the naming practice that holds by default in a community and to install another as the default. Drawing on empirical studies of chosen names, I argue that trans people select names by their social, classificatory, infrastructural, and self-constructive content, and that this content is what the purpose of a chosen name is. Using Goffman's (1959) notions of line-taking and facework, I then argue that offering a chosen name is an opening gambit whose uptake accumulates across a community rather than occurring at once, and that successful renaming is a markedness reversal. That is, the chosen name becomes the community's default while the prior name becomes marked and eventually legible as refusal rather than error. Two upshots follow for the recent debate between Camp (2025) and Nowak and Michaelson (2025) over whether the social richness characteristic of nicknames distinguishes them from names people "go-by." Against Nowak and Michaelson, "go-by" names are a real category, since without one, renaming would have no success condition. Counter to Camp, what makes a name a go-by name is not that its framing effects are incidental, but its standing as a community's most widely ratified naming practice.

1. Introduction

When transgender people change their names, on the surface, it might look simply like a choice that classifies them as a different gender. On a familiar Kripkean picture of names, renaming oneself is just to introduce a new device that classifies its bearer's gender differently. On this kind of baptismal picture, any subsequent person who encountered the new name would be in a position to use it as they would be with any other name. So, the act of renaming would be complete at the name's introduction. However, in this paper, I'll argue that when it comes to *trans renaming*, so described, this picture fails, and that seeing how it fails yields an account of trans renaming worth having in its own right.

In what follows I argue that trans renaming is a *replacement practice*: an attempt to displace the naming practice that currently holds by default within a community and install another in its place. Michaelson (2022) describes the general phenomenon, and trans renaming is a case in which the displacement is deliberate, contested, and observable while it happens. The account has four parts. First, a chosen name is selected for what it can do socially. Empirical work documents trans people choosing names by gendered legibility, class and generational connotation, and phonaesthetic fit among other considerations. The social content of the name is the criterion of selection rather than a byproduct of it. Second, offering that name is an opening gambit in Goffman's (1959) sense, a line taken which only secures a social identity when one's interlocutors accept the line. Third, uptake of the chosen name is not an event, but an accumulation. Each use, correction to the chosen name is a discrete act that can be withheld, and so labor for a successful renaming is distributed unevenly across a community. Last, accumulation produces a markedness reversal. A chosen name begins as the marked alternative and becomes the default; whereas, the prior name begins as the default and becomes marked, eventually becoming legible as an act of refusal rather than mere lapse. The success conditions of trans renaming them are when that reversal becomes pervasive across a community of practice.

This account is worth having independently of what it settles about names more generally. Recent work in social philosophy of language has described the ways a speech act can be well-

formed and still fail to receive uptake: Langton (1993) on illocutionary disablement, Kukla (2014) on distortion of performative force given a speaker's social position, and Hesni (2018) on frustration as a failure mode distinct from silencing. Kukla and Lance (2022) extend these questions of uptake to gender directly by arguing that gender ascriptions require second-person uptake to become socially operative. In renaming that requirement is highly visible and highly demanding. Each interlocutor must learn a chosen name, use it, and correct themselves and others individually. What makes renaming legible is then the distribution of the labor by which gendering is sustained in these cases. Gendering is a standing achievement rather than an ascription made once and a concrete instance of how, as Eckart and McConnell Jeanne (2003) argue, language constructs and is constructed by gender. I take it to be a morally loaded instance of a broader phenomenon; renaming on immigration, religious, ancestral, or marital grounds plausibly shares the structure described here.

Philosophy has been slow to the social life of names, trailing the work of sociolinguists and anthropologists[1]. Recently, however, Camp (2025) and Nowak & Michaelson (2025) have turned the discourse toward the social and pragmatic function of names, and the account above bears on their disagreement in a way that has gone unnoticed. The dominant view in philosophy follows Mill (1843) and Kripke (1980) in holding that the meaning of a name consists solely in its capacity to refer. Camp argues that nicknaming challenges this thin analysis: unlike proper names (which she widens to include the names people "go by"), which function as "universally accessible referential devices," a characteristic feature of nicknames is to mark restrictions on their acceptable users and uses, and so mark social status by locating the speaker and addressee within a bounded group. Nowak & Michelson don't contest that nicknames play this role, but that it sets them apart from "go-by" names. They argue that competence with names in general permits the full range of socially significant actions Camp identifies.

Two upshots on this debate follow from engagement with trans renaming. Against Nowak and Michaelson's doubt that "individuals actually bear anything remotely like neutral 'go by' names," renaming requires the category. A practice whose success consists in displacing whatever naming practice holds by default is unintelligible unless there is such a thing as a default practice. [2] And counter to Camp, renaming puts pressure on the distinction between social meaning that a name is characteristically *for* and social meaning that a name merely *happens* to carry. Camp grants that go by names can be socially rich; what she reserves for nicknames is that face work is their characteristic function. [3] However, chosen names are picked

[1] The earliest work on the social features and function of names in sociolinguistics dates back to Alford (1988).

[2] For the purposes of this paper, I will not address instances of chosen name usage, in which a trans person is assumed to be cisgender, as this paper focuses on the features of renaming that occur over the process of introducing a chosen name in a community where a previous name is operant and how the chosen name becomes dominant (or is railroaded). I suspect that when a chosen name is introduced to a community who has no knowledge of the prior name and the trans person is assumed to be cisgender, the chosen name will function like any other typical go by name. Given this, I focus on the context in which I take trans renaming to have features that make it different from typical naming practices.

[3] Though, it is worthy of note that she is careful in this connection. Section IV of her paper grants at length that proper names carry framing content. She even notes that people "sometimes renounce given names for failure of fit, whether because of a change in gender, marital, or religious status." However, she argues that for nicknames, a characteristic part of their function, is to leverage rich social meaning in ways that it is often merely incidental to go-

for the face work they do, while aiming at precisely the unrestricted accessibility that nicknames forego. Chosen names are frequently ordinary go-by names (e.g., ‘Michael’, ‘Elliot’). What makes a name a go-by name, I can conclude, is not the incidentality of its social content but its standing as the most widely ratified naming practice for a person within a community of practice (Eckert & McConnell-Ginet 2003).

The paper is structured as follows. Section 2 introduces the framework this paper needs from Camp and Nowak & Michaelson alongside a tripartite distinction from sociolinguistics between social classificatory, infrastructural, and self-constructive content. Section 3 describes how trans people choose names and shows that the practice is deeply characteristically social as a part of the function of renaming in all three respects. Section 4 argues that renaming is a speech practice aimed at replacing go-by naming practices and succeeds when the chosen name becomes the unmarked alternative. Second 5 concludes.

2. Names

This section of the paper is split into three subsections, which outline theoretical framework, both from philosophy of language's recent turn to the social meaning of names and sociolinguistic and anthropological work on naming as social practice. Both are developed in this section as tools, and where this paper's account actually parts ways with Camps and Nowak and Michelson's theories is given in Section 4.

In analytic philosophy, the debate over names has centered on what linguistic competence with names consists of. For my purposes, I will divide this debate into two camps: a Fregean analysis and a Millian[4] one. Both camps agree that names refer to people, places, and things. The Millians’ analysis of names insists that this is all there is to knowing the meaning of a name. The Fregean analysis, on the other hand, explains the cognitive value of names by positing “sense” as a layer of meaning, which describes *how we think about the objects we name*.[5] By the Millian account, ‘Marilyn Monroe’ and ‘Norma Jeane Mortenson’ have the same referent and so have the same meaning. But for the Fregean, ‘Marilyn Monroe’ and ‘Norma Jeane Mortenson’ have different meanings because they present the referent to thinkers in distinct ways.

The debate surrounding names has focused on what is required for a name to successfully refer, and neither theory particularly seeks to evaluate the social factors associated with naming. As such, both theories take for granted that names are a universally accessible referential device – anyone who meets that threshold can use the name to successfully refer.

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by names. The disagreement I push in this paper is about whether the characteristic function/incidental distinction between go-by and nicknames sorts names the way she takes it to.

[4] Of which the Kripkeans are a kind. The Kripkean analysis goes one detail further than Millianism and agrees that all there is to knowing the meaning of a name is knowing that it refers. However, Kripke adds that that this competence with this referential connection grounds out in a causal-historical account which only requires that one has encountered some token of the name and taken it up in one’s lexicon. By this account, that mere encounter with the token ensures one’s position in the causal-historical chain of naming. This account has a Millian core as successful reference doesn’t depend in any way on the listener’s knowledge of the referent.

[5] For many Fregeans, this grounds out in descriptivism – the sense of the name consists in descriptive criteria which determine the referent of the name uniquely.

a. Nicknames: Facework, Boundaries, and Identity Construction

It is here that Camp (2025) intervenes in the debate. She highlights a fundamental contrast between go-by names and nicknames. Kripkean versions of Millianism theorize that competence with a name requires only that one has encountered some token of it and taking it up. That encounter secures one's place in the chain of transmission so that when one utters the name; as Nowak and Michelson (2025) gloss the Kripkean picture, "various social mechanisms kick in to ensure that it refers to the same thing as it did in the mouth of whoever one heard it from" (p. 78). The result is that names are universally accessible referential devices - anybody who understands how names work and knows that a given string is a name can use it to refer. Camp accepts this for go-by names, which she identifies by how a person "would answer if asked, 'What's your name?' in a neutral context like filling out an online survey or at a neighborhood meeting" (p. 53).

Unlike go-by names, the bar for competence with nicknames is much higher. Knowing when and which nicknames to deploy requires continual updating of the social permissibility facts associated with those names under a given group's "shifting set of social relations". On this basis, Camp (2025) takes nicknames to have several characteristic features. First, nickname use locates the speaker and addressee within an in-group of users. It is a significant social breach to utter a nickname as an outsider to a group, and likewise unacceptable to utter a nickname as an outsider. Second, nicknames locate the referent in relation to the group and so referents generally do not have control over the nicknames they receive, rather they are "thrust upon them", "representing them as others see them".

Camp argues that it is the characteristic function of nicknames to regulate social status by functioning as *marked alternatives*. Her general conception for markedness is that an expression is more marked, and so sends a stronger signal, the more established its unmarked alternative is as the default way of achieving the same end (p. 52). So, nicknames are canonically deployed where conversational participants are mutually aware of alternative naming options, and the go by name is the more widely accessible community default. In these contexts, a sincere use of the nickname "constitutes a robust, conventional signal that the speaker takes both themselves and the addressee to belong to that community and to endorse its projected relationship to the referent." (p. 55-56)

This suggests an appealing generalization: though many go-by names happen to carry social information due to their local distribution, it is not a part of their function to mark social boundaries the way it is for nicknames. As Camp (2025), "it is nicknames' job to manage base, while this is something that proper names just happen to do" (p. 63). Nicknames mark local identities and their users form a community of practice who, through joint activity, delineate "ways of doing things, ways of talking, beliefs, values, [and] power relations..." (Eckert and McConnell-Ginet 1992). That community of practices shared background includes "in-group knowledge of the nickname's history of coining and use. Contrary to this proposal, Nowak and Michaelson (2025) argue that rather than such rich social and boundary-delineating acts being characteristic of the use of nicknames, they are endemic to the use of all names.

b. All Names are Descriptively Rich & and Socially Bounded

In response to Camp's argument for the distinctiveness of nicknames, Nowak and Michaelson carve out two notions of linguistic competence with names. They argue that even if referential competence (a la Kripke 1980) requires very little in terms of cognitive significance, there is a broader notion of competence with names that is more demanding. This broader notion of competence with naming involves shareable forms of systematic social knowledge, where the manifestations vary across languages. In service of this aim, they provide evidence that it is completely pervasive for one individual to be the bearer of many names, the tokenings of which establish and reflect the different social relations which that individual has, as well as tracking facts about the social context. They take these facts to indicate that even if nicknames' status as marked alternatives is an important part of how they perform their social function, the distinction between nicknames and proper names is less important than other issues that account for those differences.

First, they argue that even for what Camp considers more typical names, knowing the name requires more than merely knowing its referent, and that the additional social meaning they describe belongs to the lexical competence associated with the name. For example, when asking your mom when a family member will arrive for Thanksgiving, 1a is not appropriate, whereas 1b is.

1a) #When will James Scalzo be here?

1b) ✓ When will Uncle Jim be here?

Nowak & Michaelson point out in saying 1b, the speaker makes a clear and substantive social move to identify a level of intimacy with the referent. Being on the wrong side of this group boundary is very apparent - either by making it clear that one, as a listener, doesn't know who is being referred to or that one is an outsider to the group insofar as this naming convention for James Scalzo would be socially impermissible to the listener. In Camp's terms, in this example "Uncle Jimmy" counts as a marked alternative – it delineates a differentiated community of practice and has a relatively high bar for entry into use.

The successful use of titles, honorifics, and kinship terms also requires sensitivity to information about social relations, authority, intimacy, and group membership. Such examples are below.

(2) A Department of Motor Vehicles employee asks you when applying for your new license what your name is:

Ethan

✓ Ethan Paul Nowak

(3) When telling your undergraduate advisor what classes you are taking this semester:

Ethan's philosophy of language seminar

✓ Dr./Professor Nowak's philosophy of language seminar

(4) When asking your mom when your family member will be arriving for Thanksgiving:

When will James Scalzo be here?

✓ When will Uncle Jimmy be here?

The use of this social information, they allege, is not optional background information. Conversational participants treat misuse of these terms as genuine linguistic errors as opposed to merely infelicitous conversational choices. They broaden this critique into a general claim about markedness: whether a given naming option counts as marked is fixed by features of the concrete speech situation, and no naming option holds default status independently of such features.

The ubiquitous nature of social information in successful reference leads Nowak & Michaelson to defend a position they call *Fregean socialism* – that understanding referring expressions requires grasping socially structured conditions of use. Any satisfactory theory of meaning, they claim, should explain the full competence speakers display with these socially governed expressions.

c. The Social Impact of Names

The view that Nowak & Michaelson end up with is closer to the direction of recent anthropological and sociolinguistic work on names, which since the 1980s has been focused on the question of *what names do in the social world: what they accomplish, how, and for whom*. This work is immensely fruitful in carving up the landscape of kinds of social meaning that a name can communicate.

In this tradition, Alford (1988), vom Bruck and Bodenhorn (2006), Pina-Cabral (2010, 2015), and Pilcher (2016, 2017) develop the argument that names are much more than mere reference-fixing labels; rather, names are *social technologies*, positioning individuals within kinship systems, religious, ethnic, and political communities, and class structures.

A social technology, for my purposes, is best understood as a culturally developed practice which helps produce and maintain social order. Under this definition, marriage, bureaucratic records, and caste labels are all examples of social technologies as cultural practices, institutions, or symbolic systems which enable people to organize social relationships, classify individuals, and distribute rights and obligations. Names, in the tradition these authors typify, perform three major functions, (i) social classification, (ii) social infrastructure maintenance, and (iii) self-construction.

Alford (1988) gives the clearest initial demonstration of names as social classification devices – he argues that naming makes people socially recognizable by linking them to larger social structures through marking things like lineage, social rank, and religious affiliation. Alford suggests that patronymic naming systems mark lineage through surname – 'Johnson' and 'Ivanovich' have a "son of X" construction, and names often give religious affiliation cues such as 'Mary', 'Abraham', or 'Muhammad'. Vom Bruck and Bodenhorn (2006) argue that besides classification, names are mechanisms of social continuity – they can circulate independently of

the individual through genealogies, legal records, and collective memory and, as such, names function as *infrastructure* in social systems. Consider an example surname like 'Kennedy' – it allows social institutions and families to track things like who belongs to a lineage, who might inherit property, and who counts as kin. Names, in this light, organize entire networks of relationships and social obligations, rather than functioning as mere identifiers or classifiers.

Pina-Cabral (2010, 2015) takes this argument one step further. His central concern is the relationship between names and personhood, claiming that "self-building is both a condition for language and a result of language". He suggests that, as a technology of self-construction, names help produce social identity, continuity of the self, and self-recognition and recognition by others, which he argues tracks how people distinguish and identify their "true names". He starts from an observation – people frequently utter things like:

- Yes, people call me X, but my real name is Y.
- That doesn't feel like my name.
- This is who I really am.

Such responses occur in situations involving legal names, nicknames, pseudonyms, religious names, and family names. The puzzle for Pina-Cabral, then, is if all names simply refer to the same person, why do people consistently differentiate among them in terms of authenticity? He argues that the answer to this question is that names play a critical stabilizing role in personhood – a "true name" is just the name most strongly connected to a person's sense of being one coherent socially-recognized self across the many social roles they occupy. Pilcher (2017) draws these three strands together by arguing that names must be understood as embodied words where all three components of social meaning work together at once on a named body rather than in separate registers.

3. Chosen Names

Here I present the empirical work on trans chosen names, organized by the three functions just distinguished. The connection is almost immediate: Trans people describe choosing names by exactly the considerations that Alford, von Brock and Bodenhorn, and Pina Cabral identify. I address them in the order of personhood, classification, and infrastructure. I begin with the criterion (personhood) participants report as most important and work outward to the considerations that involve other people.[6]

a. Personhood: names that "feel like one's own"

Across empirical studies, trans participants evaluate candidate names first by whether they "feel like one's own". Leino (2014) found that the most important criterion for choosing a new name, with an average of 3.7 and variance of 0.3 on a four-point scale. Participants in Pamfile et al. (2024), Kinney, Muzzey & McCauley (2021), and VanderSchans (2016) provide

[6] Chosen names also assist in identity construction in the additional signaling force that comes from people knowing that they're chosen. This amounts to the distinction between how being named 'Muhammad Ali' conditions people's perceptions of the boxer because of associations with the name that would have remained intact if he had been given that name at birth, and then there is the way that knowing that he *chose* 'Muhammad Ali' conditions people's perceptions of him.

concrete cases of identity-based fit. They report coming to a name because “it suited me very well”, frame renaming as a form of rebirth or narrative transformation, and connect chosen names with “reclaiming oneself” and self-awareness.

The fit at stake is more than just general gender inflection. Participants describe choosing names because they reflect a specific desired model of gender in the world. One trans woman interviewed by Cuba (2024) chose the name ‘Lesly’ because she met a teaching trainee who was “pretty, intelligent, and educated” and “saw herself reflected” in that name and version of femininity.This is precisely what Pena Cabral theorizes: that a chosen name is a true name because it is the one most strongly connected to a sense of being a coherent, socially recognized self.

Once secured, personal fit also serves as a buffer against outside objection. VanderSchans (2015) points out that once trans people choose new names, resonance with their personal identity can lessen the authority of outside objections to the name. Holly, in that study, explained that she felt her name to be so personally fitting that she was unmoved by family and friends concerns that the name sound like a “stripper name”.

b. Classification: legibility to others

A chosen name must also manage gender legibility, misgendering risk, kinship, professional perception, and cultural belonging. The second and third of Leino (2014) top three criteria for new names were that the name must “be correctly gendered” and “not be incorrectly gendered”.

Participants across studies report evaluating candidates for whether they reduce misgendering, secure family acceptance, and professional viability. One participant chose a common feminine name because she “wanted to be clear for everybody what pronoun they should use”, while another balanced wanting a “unique” name with not wanting an interviewer to think it was “a silly name”. *Anna*, where Holly had set the same worry aside, avoided names that might sound like a “stripper’s name”, which ruled out ‘Brenda’ for her, to ensure that her new name indexed a “softer” and “quieter” performance of femininity. (VanderSchans 2015). Transmasculine participants show the same sensitivity. VanderSchans quotes one on ‘Kevin’ as "an appalling choice of a name; it jars for many when it turns out I'm not a working-class man from the 1980s."

These reports track much more specific classificatory perceptions than simply the marked gender of a name. Trans people are reporting sensitivity to the class, generation, and stereotypically gendered traits a name connotes, which Alford and others have already observed cisgender names carry.[7] Finnish non-binary people surveyed in Valijarvi & Woodmeade (2025) chose names considered less gender-affiliated moving to bisyllabic nature-themed[8] common nouns (e.g. ‘Halla’ → “frosty conditions”, ‘Myrsky’ → “storm”, ‘Saarni’ → “ash tree”, ‘Sumu’

[7] Note that for my purposes, these perceptions do not have to be objectively right. What matters is whether the individual is taking into consideration classification markers that they think others will pick up on and weighing those markers in their choice.

[8] Other names, not specifically nature-themed, included names that were “space-themed”, and poetry/music based common nouns.

→ “fog”). Participants indicated that such names serve as a pseudo-conventionalized marker for their gender absence, signaling non-binary affiliation. By choosing a word which directly eschews the typical binary gender affiliations of more common names, they aim at the same classificatory function by inverting it.

c. Infrastructure: easing the transition

Trans people also manage the process by which a new name will be taken up, and this management is visible in the names they choose. Many arrive at new names through derivation (e.g. Gerado → Gerarda, ‘Elys’ → ‘Ellis’), which preserve biographical and familial continuity. Phono-acoustic similarities are reported to be chosen for the practical result of easing the naming shift of the trans person’s social circle. Some non-binary people report having gone, at some stage by a name that was a shortened or gender-modified version of their birth name for the same reason (e.g. ‘Lindsay’ → ‘Lin’, ‘Brianna’ → ‘Bri’, ‘Matthew’ → ‘Mattie’). Initials work the same way. One person described the author choosing "Shawn" because it shared an initial \sh sound with his prior name while retaining his given initials.

The considerations also extend to how a name will sit in a family's existing naming practice. Participants in the cited studies chose names common among boys in their family, or names their mothers might have chosen if they had been assigned male at birth, as well as names with the same roots or symbolic connections as the given name. Some participants in a Western European study described involving their family members in the choice – choosing names that their parents and siblings liked or thought fit them.

Participants were explicit that maintaining such features would ease the naming transition. Keeping the same initials would ease the cognitive shift for family members and friends and would preserve some of the material “infrastructure” of the name – in family trees and lineage documents, so that family would not see them as wholly abandoning the prior name. These are choices made about other people’s capacity and willingness to adopt the name before the new name has been offered to the community as a replacement.[9]

d. What the choice shows

Two threads run through this research. Every chosen name simultaneously engages and weights both functions of naming that Section 2 distinguished: it assists an individual become someone to themselves and in becoming recognizable in that identity to others. The second of these divides inn two. Chosen names must achieve *legibility* –the framing effects by which an interlocutor can recognize the identity being claimed – and they must secure *ease of uptake* – the features that lower the costs to others of shifting their referential habits. Legibility is a feature of the name, whereas ease of uptake is a feature of the renaming process. Subsections a and b predominantly concerned the first, whereas c (and Section 4) concern the second.

However, none of this fixes a ranking among the considerations identified above. The same one can be decisive for one person and dismissible for another. Holly and Anna,

[9] There is a plausible analysis of these strategic features of trans renaming as a kind of metalinguistic negotiation (Plunkett & Sundell). I think this is a worthwhile connection that could be considered at length in future work.

participants in the same study, weighed an identical worry to opposite conclusions. They both considered whether a name would be read as a "stripper name", however Holly set it aside because of strength of personal fit, while for Anna it eliminated a candidate name outright. The balance described at the outset of this section, between how one sees oneself and how one wishes to be seen, is struck differently by different individuals. It is important because it's indicative of the kind of thing that a chosen name is. If a name's social content were simply carried along with it, there would be little to weigh and no room for weighing to come out to different choices. That the choice does come out differently for different individuals shows, or actually is evidence of, the deliberative process. Trans individuals are assessing what a name will do, assigning that weight against competing considerations, and choosing accordingly.

In Camp's (2025) terms, these names are deeply loaded with framing content. They are picked for the way they encapsulate specific ways of parsing, selecting, and prioritizing information about the referent. Trans individuals across the gender spectrum report choosing new names for what a name tells an interpreter their gender as it fits into their broader social identity.[10] This is why some people are drawn to traditional names and others to unusual ones, and why fit is assessed via many different metrics. By choosing on these various grounds, trans people are handling names as what Pilcher (2016, 2017) calls "Goffman-style identity pegs." Chosen names are performative identifiers that ask observers to credit the bearer with the attributes they appear to have and trans individuals evaluate whether a name matches the "manner" and "appearance" they take themselves to be performing.

The features that I have cataloged in this section, including gendered legibility, misgendering risk, class and generational connotation, among others, are a criterion of selection of the name, not a property a chosen name incidentally turns out to have. In section 4, I turn to asking a more local question: what has to happen, conversation by conversation, for trans renaming practice to be successful? The answer I argue that renaming is a social move to replace a previously established and dominant naming practice with a new one. This move's success depends on the community involved, and understood this way, requires the social recognition of the "go-by" naming practice, that Nowak & Michaelson's (2025) doubt.[11]

4. Trans Renaming Practices

In section 3, I argued that a chosen name's social content is what the name is selected for, and not an incidental property it happens to have. However, I left yet unaddressed what marks the boundary between go-by names and nicknames, since Camp reserves the property of face work as a nickname's job rather than something it happens to do. Addressing this requires

[10] It is worth noting that this practice is not exclusive to the modern trans community. Historical examples of butch cis- and trans- lesbians choosing names which evoke a non-cis masculinity include Storme DeLaverie, Les (originally a middle name) Feinburg, Gladys Bentley/Bobbie Minton, Corky Davies).

[11] I leave it to further research as to how much this differs from renaming for the purpose of immigration, personal identity fit, or other reasons. I think an entirely plausible broad story of renaming is that in all these cases names are devices of direct reference that carry widely known information about the communities in which they have widespread use, and that information can get leveraged for additional communicative force and identity construction. This would make transgender renaming a singular instance of a broader phenomenon, that has substantial moral and communicative weight due to the marginalization of trans people in most communities.

turning from how names are chosen to how they come to be used in communities and conversations. This section describes renaming as a linguistic process: an opening gambit that must be taken up, sustained by interactional labor, and accumulating uses across a given community until the new name displaces the old as the unmarked default.

Two results follow. Against Nowak and Michelson, renaming has no success condition unless names can hold default status independent of the features of particular contexts. Emergent from this section's description of the renaming process, I suggest go-by naming is best conceptualized as the most widely ratified naming practice for a person within a community, which is a matter of standing rather than content.

a. Naming as a positioning act

The supra-conversational effects of trans renaming are dependent on our conversation-level linguistic practice. Social identity in conversation has been described similarly across sociolinguistics and more recent work in non-ideal philosophy of language. Bucholtz & Hall (2005) describe social identity as emerging through persistent fleeting interactions in what they call *stance accretion*. *Stances* in their view are "the display of evaluative, affective, and epistemic orientations in discourse". So defined, stances are like Goffman's (1959) notion of "taking a line" as described by Berstler (ms.).

In Berstler's reconstruction, *taking a line* describes the open expression by a conversational participant of their evaluation of themselves, other participants, and the nature of the social interaction. Taking lines that *harmonize* across participants leads to *a working consensus*, where each participant's "face" is what the working consensus entails about that participant. *Facework*, then, according to Berstler, is best described as what individuals, in social interaction, do to keep the working consensus from collapsing.[12] In sociolinguistics, Bucholtz and Hall (2005) can be interpreted as extending this conversation-level view to a structural one: arguing that a consistent working consensus across conversations and participants, which they call "stance accretion", leads to more than just stabilized encounters, but rather stabilizes emerging macro-level identities. How exactly that happens is not theorized explicitly on either Bucholtz & Hall's theory or Goffman's – who Berstler describes as focused on fragility of image maintenance in interaction.

Kukla (2018) and Kukla & Lance (2022) provide a helpful bridge to how macro-level identity features can emerge and be maintained through conversational interaction – some speech

[12] This work is quite similar theoretically to Bucholtz & Hall's (2005) sociolinguistics theory of identity as a discourse emergent property through *stance accretion*. Their theory entails that *partial* identities *emerge* through social *positionality*, *indexical* linguistic forms, and *relational* social behavior.

Berstler's precisification of Goffman correlates: faces (identities for Bucholtz and Hall) are co-constructed (emergent and relational), ephemeral (positional), provisional, and legalistic, and developed through the incremental work of line-taking (stances).

Bucholtz & Hall's theory is interesting in its own right. However, given that this paper is situated within analytic philosophy of language and this section focuses on the emergence of chosen names as unmarked alternatives, I utilize the theoretical framework Berstler (ms) describes.

acts, they argue, are claims to social position that require *uptake* to become socially operative. On their description, these socially addressed acts exercise authority, establish permissions, impose norms, and alter someone's position.

They use this picture to describe gender attribution and denial. First-person gender attribution (e.g. "I am a man."), they argue, is a social proposal rather than a description of fact. Second-person gender denial (e.g. "No, you are not a man.") is a rejection of the first speaker's attempt to organize social space and place themselves within in it in a specific way. These denials are explicit repudiations of the call for social uptake. Similarly, if the second speaker instead responded affirmatively (e.g. "Yes, you are a man"), they are giving social uptake and placing the first speaker in the social location that they made a petition for. Critically, on their view, claiming a position in normative space without receiving uptake means that nothing holds one in that social space.

Put together, these theoretical pieces provide the following picture of trans renaming as a social speech *practice*, which I detail in the following subsections. Renaming is an instance of taking a line, which goes from a risky conversational maneuver to a default one as it receives uptake in a community of practice.

b. Chosen Names and Opening Gambits

Not every line is equally easy to take. Berstler describes how conversational participants often signal their intended line through an "opening gambit", defined as an initial move that either succeeds or fails to carry enough information for interlocutors to recognize the proposed line and harmonize it with their own. The first time a trans person offers a chosen name to a group of interlocutors for whom a previous name was already in use is exactly this kind of gambit. At this stage, the chosen name has not yet accrued any uptake within this community, and so there is no precedent that grounds the name as expected or unremarkable. In Camp's (2025) terms, the name is, at this stage, a fully marked alternative: its use signals deviation from mutual baseline expectations.

The risk has significant practical ramifications. Trans renaming is an especially delicate task because in the initiation of every trans renaming attempt, there is an alternative competing naming practice available. In other "lines" that one takes, one might try to cultivate an identity that someone refuses to harmonize with – friend, manager, parental figure. However, there is not always, in these cases, an immediate, alternative current practice that one can reach for instead. For example. I might want you to treat me as your friend and instead you treat me as merely a person who attends NYC DSA meetings. However, that isn't necessarily the current line that you and I have harmonized on. We might just never have harmonized at all. In trans renaming, on the other hand, trans individuals had a given name or an affiliate of their given name that their communities used, and that they had tacitly agreed to. That identity and line harmonized across conversations, interactions, and communities. Trans renaming is a distinct rupture to a previously established, harmonized line, rather than merely the introduction of a new one. This makes deadnaming a failure distinct from mere non-uptake. Non-uptake, as described above, is passive:

an interlocutor simply doesn't adopt the new line. However, deadnaming is an active refusal: a competing line is asserted instead, backed by the previously harmonized name. [13,14]

This description of renaming as initiated by an opening gambit rife with risk is exemplified by empirical results from Kinney and Muzzey (2020). Participants in their study often first try out new names with trust friends, queer peers, roommates, or therapists before extending them outward to family, school, healthcare, and work. Each community of practice accrues uptake and stabilizes at its own pace.

c. Sustaining the line and the labor of uptake

Success at the opening gambit only begins the interactional labor required to sustain a line. Correcting, using, avoiding, or repairing name use are all ways of maintaining or threatening the working consensus around this new interactional self. Berstler (ms) calls this ongoing labor *facework* and *tact*.[15] Facework is the performance or rejection thereof in order to reduce the risk that someone within an encounter discredits the working consensus. Second-order tact are the actions we take "so as to make it possible and even easy for…others to employ face-work for themselves and [us]. Both facework and second-order tact aim to keep a working consensus from collapsing once it has been provisionally reached.

Consider a brief example in which one neighbor, Fatima, is meeting someone new to the neighborhood, Caleb, for the first time and the conversation is winding down.

> Fatima: Anyway, if there's anything at all that my husband and I can do for you, please don't hesitate to ask.
>
> Caleb: Really? That's so kind!
>
> Fatima: Yes, of course. We're here for you.
>
> Caleb: Well actually, there is something…could I stay at your house for the next five days – we are doing demolition work to make an addition.[16]

The failure conversationally in such an example is two-fold. First, Caleb's question makes it difficult for Fatima to continue to take her line because he hasn't performed the second-order tact that Fatima expected him to. Fatima expects Caleb to recognize that she likely doesn't mean to suggest that she is willing or able to be that generous upon their first meeting, and in response to her verbal generosity she expects Caleb to be mindful of what is or is not a reasonable request. Second, this failure of second-order tact means that Fatima has to find a way to prevent discrediting the working consensus in light of the unexpected request.

[13] It seems entirely plausible on this account that simply refusing to name someone at all also counts as an active refusal as it is still backed by and taps into a previously harmonized line.

[14] Kukla and Lance's (2022) account accords with Berstler in arguing that identity uptake is interactional. They describe second-person uptake as necessary for gender ascriptions to be socially operant. Self-identification alone is not sufficient to constitute a position in social space, which means that every opening gambit, especially when ideologically loaded, is, by construction, a bid that can fail in ways that ground outsized practical risk.

[15] Facework is a kind of tact, however second-order tact is described as distinct from facework.

[16] The example, while taken from Berstler (ms) has been modified slightly purely for readability. The core idea is the same.

Kinney and Muzzey's participants give many examples of both individual facework and instances of second-order tact used to sustain a chosen name. For example, as the trusted circle of new name users expands, trans individuals often have to engage with family, friends, colleagues, and schools to receive uptake. They defend and explain name choices, involve family in the choice, and find compromises between their choice and a given name temporarily. One individual (p.c.) reported that to ease their mother's difficulty with a new name, they let their mother use their old nickname until their mother found a different nickname associated with the chosen name. This tact is performed jointly: the trans individual accommodates a transitional line (the old nickname) precisely in order to keep the working consensus from collapsing outright, while still steering it toward the eventual target.

The amount of facework that one must do for one's new name and gender identity to be received can be immense. Naming is an intensely personal practice (as Camp 2025 illustrates) and facilitating ease and effortlessness of interaction goes a long way towards individual harmonizations that establish and maintain working consensus for a chosen name. This, theoretically, makes sense of why there is so much consideration, on a trans person's part, of fit, relation to a past name, and tacit approval by close friends and family.

However, tact is not something that only the name-bearer performs. Uptake must be given by one's interlocutor and so the burden of sustaining a working consensus is unevenly distributed. How much facework an interlocutor is willing to do on behalf of a trans person's chosen name (e.g. finding a nickname compromise, correcting themselves consistently, correcting others, and updating informal records) is a site of variation with substantial stakes for the degree to which a chosen name can itself become the default.

d. How accumulated lines become dominant

As the social uptake of a trans person's chosen name is increasingly widely successful[17], it can change what counts as a marked alternative. Several participants in Kinney & Muzzey (2020), and Kinney, Muzzey, & McCauley (2021) report that as more of their friends and family accept and utilize the new name, it makes it more socially risky for noncompliant family members to use a prior name. This suggests that, like nicknames, trans chosen names do have marked alternatives, but which name, given or chosen, is the marked alternative comes from the dominance of the practice itself. Camp (2025) describes marked alternatives for nicknames as follows:

> ...to the extent that conversational participants are mutually aware of alternate naming options for a single individual, where one option is mutually known to be strongly associated with a strongly differentiated community of practice and the other is known to be a more widely accessible default, a sincere use of the former constitutes a robust, conventional signal that the speaker takes both themselves and the addressee to belong to that community and to endorse its projected relationship to the referent. (6)

[17] In other words, as a working consensus is established and reinforced within more and more of the community of practice.

This description of a marked alternative can be applied both to a new name and a prior name at different points in the renaming process.

When a trans person first introduces a new name for themselves, the chosen name is marked (as described in IVb). It is the non-dominant naming practice, and to use it marks a substantial social move that demonstrates an individual's willingness to reorganize their referential practices around you and your gender identity. The interlocutor willing to utilize the chosen name in their own communication about you is taking a potentially risky line themselves with respect to how they recognize your gender identity. Taken together with Kinney & Muzzey's description of the risk of using a prior name increasing in tandem with its increasing use in the community, this demonstrates a markedness reversal when renaming is successful.

This markedness reversal is closely tied to the way in which a line is easier to take and maintain when it is more closely tied to a social identity that has uptake with one's interlocutors. Opening gambits are hard to make, but when they are received, they establish one's conversational face. The more one's interlocutors do help maintain that face (*tact*), the more one can be confident that their identity has received uptake. That is, the conversation-level facework to maintain the line is precisely what indicates and affirms uptake. As that facework is consistently deployed across conversations and interlocutors, the chosen name becomes increasingly unmarked. Each successful instance of uptake of the name does more than add one more precedent of use. It makes the next instance of uptake more likely because it incrementally lowers the marked status of the name itself. Risk, within a harmonizing community of practice, is self-erasing because each successful gambit makes the next one less of a gambit at all.[18,19]

Sections 3 and 4 have thus far demonstrated that a chosen name is selected for and how it is positioned enables it to have maximal social impact. Its facework is a criterion of choice of the name, not something the name simply turns out to have. Further, I have shown that this face work is done unevenly by the community that takes the chosen name up. Whether a chosen name is used at all is precisely what positions the bearer. Either the bearer is recognized in their claimed gender to those who use the name or unrecognized to those who don't. This is what Camp (2025) says a name space where consists in: nicknames "manage face by... projecting social identities for their reference and by "marking social status, locating speaker and addressee within a bounded group of users and the referent on one side or the other of that boundary" (p. 51).

[18] This echoes the mechanism that Camp and Flores's (2024) account of identity labels uses. They draw on Hacking's looping effects to argue that as a label is applied and reapplied, its "interpretive and practical utility" is reinforced until it becomes "the dominant, maximally effective tool" for interpreting and interacting with the person it names. This continuity is worth marking because it looks like what holds for identity labels holds for chosen names for a similar reason.

[19] A further mark of entrenchment is that as a chosen name gains prominence, interlocutors may begin operating on it, rather than merely using it. They might shorten it, derive affectionate forms from it, and reorganize pronouns and honorifics around it. Each of these treats the chosen name as a given rather than a proposal. Producing a diminutive form of the name presupposes the standing to do so, which is a move than must be made from inside a working consensus.

This seems to make facework a characteristic function of chosen names (similar to nicknames). A chosen name's face work is its job in the same sense that "it is the nickname's job to manage face...". The chosen name is selected for and sustained by the interactional labor described in this section. Its success or failure can be tracked conversation by conversation by the community whose recognition it solicits. Further, a chosen name is, on camp's own test, a go-by name. She proposes that a name status turns on how a person "would answer if asked what's your name in a neutral context...". A trans person answers with their chosen name. It is also unrestricted in contrast to nicknames. Thus, it sits interestingly between her description of go-by names and nicknames. It is a paradigmatic go-by name insofar as it aims at unrestricted availability (which would disqualify it as a nickname). Unrestricted availability is the explicit normative goal of renaming. However, a chosen name's facework and so what it communicates is about the name standing in the community - it depends on a community knowing it was chosen, when, against what, and is sustained by that community's own practice rather than by the chooser alone.

None of this shows that Camp is wrong about nicknames. What it shows is that one of the properties she uses to sort nicknames from go-by names (whether face work is a name's job or something it merely happens to do) does not track the boundary that she suggests that it does. Chosen names, as paradigmatic go-by names, have facework as their job. What actually distinguishes a go-by name, as I will flesh out in the next section, is its standing: whether it is the naming practice that dominates in a community.

e. Renaming as Replacement of a Default Naming Practice

The picture of renaming developed so far puts pressure on Nowak and Michaelson's (2025) denial of a class of names whose default status transcends particular concrete speech situations. Recall that on their view, whether 'Ethan' or 'Ethan Paul Nowak' counts as marked depends on a wide range of situational factors (e.g. the purpose of the exchange, the ages of the participants, how others have recently introduced themselves) and no one of these forms holds default status as such. Camp's category of the 'go-by' name, a universally accessible referential option available to anyone without invoking a bounded community, is on their account an artifact of idealization rather than a real feature of naming practice. Their evidence is a series of cases in which the very same speaker, referring to the very same person, must select among naming options that shift with the occasion: the clerk's window, the cocktail party, the family dinner at which 'Uncle Jimmy' but not 'James Scalzo' is appropriate.

Trans renaming constitutes a counterexample to this denial. The problem is that if markedness were exhausted by features of the immediate speech situation, then there would be no sense in which a name could *become* less marked over time as a cumulative social achievement, because there would be nothing that carries over between occasions to accumulate. But this is precisely what the renaming process involves. Aggregated uptake makes subsequent uptake more likely and less effortful; participants describe their own renaming trajectories as expanding outward from the most intimate members of the community to acquaintances; and the broadening, when successful within a community of practice, is carried forward by that community rather than renegotiated from scratch each time two of its members speak. What is

being tracked is the chosen name's accumulated social history, not the features of any single exchange.

An especially clear piece of evidence for this comes the decline of a prior name. Deadnaming, the continued or reanimated use of a trans person's prior name, is a strategy that is, in some sense, always available. Deadnaming requires no novel coinage or negotiation because it hooks onto a naming practice that was previously the settled default across a trans person's communities. Deadnaming is a way of describing that what a prior name *signals* changes dramatically over the course of the renaming process, and it changes in a direction that tracks the entrenchment of the chosen name in reverse. Early on, when the chosen name is still the marked alternative and the prior name still enjoys something like default status, use of the prior name is barely marked at all. It's use, though improper and harmful, is often indistinguishable from habit, ignorance, or cognitive error, and it is frequently treated as such by trans people themselves, who describe extending patience, offering compromises, and doing considerable facework to ease the transition. As uptake accumulates and the chosen name approaches default status within a community of practice, the same utterance, produced by the same speaker in the same sort of setting, becomes an increasingly loaded social act. It is now legible as a choice rather than a mere lapse, and eventually as a deliberate reassertion of a displaced practice against its replacement.[20]

The reason deadnaming is read as refusal rather than as error is that the interlocutors mutually recognize that the prior name once held legitimate default status and is now being reached for against a name that has displaced it. If names did not persist as defaults across occasions, then deadnaming would carry the same weight as any other situationally inapt naming choice. Calling someone by their prior name would be the same kind of linguistic error as calling a stranger at a cocktail party by their full three-part legal name. However, deadnaming is received as an act of contestation of identity, and the charge is increasingly likely to be levelled as the new name entrenches.

Nowak and Michaelson might respond that what I am describing as accumulated default status is actually consistency of situational cues across many relevantly similar occasions. One doesn't need to posit any transcendent default to explain why Ethan's mother says 'Uncle Jimmy' whenever she is speaking to Ethan and 'Jimmy' whenever she is speaking to her friends. One only need recognize stable features across contexts, and the naming choice tracks them. Trans renaming, one might argue is the same: what looks like a name becoming the default is really just a set of recurring contexts in which the same situational factors reliably obtain. However, in cases of deadnaming, one can hold the interlocutor, the register, the setting, and the referential purpose fixed, and *still* observe the social meaning of the utterance shift over time. The mother who uses her child's prior name at the family dinner table in month one of them coming out has had a simple cognitive lapse, but the mother who uses that same name at that same table in

[20] Described this way, the features of deadnaming described here align more closely with the speech act-oriented view of deadnaming articulated in Klieber and Bolton (forthcoming) and the descriptions of linguistic authority in Lane (2025a), than Lane (2025b) and Koles (2024). Nonetheless, due to space constraints, I leave closer comparisons of the features of deadnaming described here to currently available views for future work.

month twenty-four is being deliberately resistant, and yet they are not responding to different situational cues. Between the two instances the social standing of the name has changed.

Deadnaming and renaming are only describable in this way if go-by names can hold default status across contexts. Names must be able to hold default status, have their default status contested, lose that status when a new practice dominates, and be able to be reasserted against successor names. A chosen name's entrenchment shows that default status can be acquired through accumulated uptake. Deadnaming shows that loss of default status of a given name is clear enough to interlocutors that reaching for it is recognizable as refusal. so, renaming is an attempt to eliminate a prior name's standing across contexts. This is why partial success, acceptance at work but not at home, or from friends but not from family, is often experienced as failure rather than as ordinary situational variation.[21] So, even when the chosen name is entrenched, it carries the history of its own installation as a practice. This includes the prior practice it displaced and in displacing that practice the reorganization of the social relations, gendered expectations, and interpretive frames attached to the person it names. This is what makes deadnaming an act of contestation rather than an ordinary misfire; the entrenched chosen name, even when unmarked is not socially weightless.[22]

5. Conclusion

Trans renaming practices highlight a feature of personal names that is obscured when philosophy treats names primarily as reference fixing devices. Naming is a socially embedded practice for positioning people, and trans renaming makes this particularly clear. Chosen names must both bear the social and personal weight of gendered self-construction, and become ordinarily and widely available enough to serve as the person’s operative go-by name. Though these may look like competing demands, in this paper, I have argued that they are not.

Renaming is a practice that uses the former to successfully produce the latter. Chosen names are selected for the social positioning work they do rather, they acquire standing as uptake accumulates across a community, and they succeed only when the new practice has displaced the prior practice that had standing. What changes over the course of that process is names’ position in a community’s linguistic practices. Renaming causes markedness reversal upon which the prior name, once largely unmarked becomes the marked option, and reach for it becomes legible as refusal and not mere error. What makes a name a go-by name is thus the breadth of its ratification; using it becomes what a community does by default.

Ultimately, rather than asking whether names are semantically thin or socially rich, we should consider how naming practices distribute social meaning and referential authority across communities of practice. Trans renaming shows that a name can be maximally socially

[21] One way to interpret this account is that a completely successful renaming is self-effacing. It turns a chosen name into an ordinary go-by name. However, within a community that took on the renaming process, the chosen name still carries the history of its own rise to dominance. This is what makes the asymmetry in deadnaming available.

[22] This also suggests an explanation for why in communities where no one is aware a renaming occurred, the chosen name functions like a typical go-by name. In such communities, there was no previous practice operative and so the chosen name has no renaming history to carry.

meaningful precisely because it is trying to become maximally standard. Chosen names' success lies in moving beyond being restricted or marked, and increasingly distributing the individual's identity across ever widening communities of practice.

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